

Poland

 This country of medieval towns and scattered farms and villages has a history of invasion and occupation by foreign powers. From 1945 to 1989, Poland was a communist state. Since the collapse of communism, however, Poland has been experiencing massive economic, social, and political change. Poland has a strong strategic position between eastern and western Europe and joined NATO in 1999.

Warsaw

Poland's capital since the 1500s, Warsaw was almost completely destroyed during World War II (1939–45). Working from original plans, paintings, and photographs, the Poles have rebuilt the city, restoring its ancient landmarks and treasured buildings. Today, the reconstructed buildings line wide streets and squares.

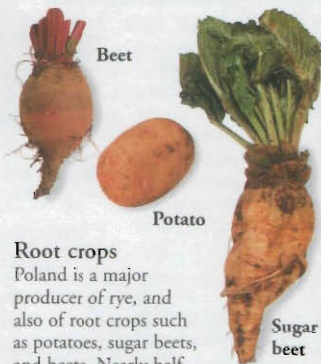


Old Town Square



People

Like the neighbouring Czechs and Slovaks, Poles originate from the Slavic peoples of Europe. Poland has few ethnic minorities, and more than 95 per cent of the people are Polish-speaking Roman Catholics. Many Poles have a traditional way of life; local folk arts and crafts flourish. These include wood carving and colourful embroidery.



Root crops

Poland is a major producer of rye, and also of root crops such as potatoes, sugar beets, and beets. Nearly half the land is used to grow crops or raise livestock, particularly pigs. State farms account for about 10 per cent of this land. Most privately owned farms are small, producing some crops to sell, and the rest to feed farmers' families. Farming employs a quarter of Poland's work-force.



Wheat

Poland's leading grain crop is wheat, although yields are poor. Two-thirds of the wheat is fed to livestock, some, with potatoes, is used to distil vodka, and with the rest, farmers bake bread.

POLAND FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Warsaw
AREA	312,680 sq km (120,720 sq miles)
POPULATION	38,800,000
DENSITY	127 per sq km (330 per sq mile)
MAIN LANGUAGE	Polish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Zloty
LIFE EXPECTANCY	73 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	435
GOVERNMENT	Multiparty democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%



Industry

About one-fifth of Poland's labour force works in industry, but production in the huge old Soviet-style factories is inefficient. In order to compete on the free market, the government is slowly privatizing industry. Shipbuilding is an important industry on the Baltic Coast, and the Gdansk shipyard is one of several. Poland has a thriving iron and steel industry, and big reserves of coal, lignite (brown coal), copper, lead, silver, and zinc.

Czech Republic

 The Czech Republic consists of the two ancient states of Bohemia and Moravia, which once formed part of the Holy Roman Empire. From 1918, it was part of Czechoslovakia and only emerged as an independent country in 1993, when Czechoslovakia was partitioned. The Czech Republic is central Europe's most industrialized nation, and manufacturing employs 40 per cent of its work-force.

Prague

One of the most beautiful capital cities in Europe, Prague has remained virtually unchanged for centuries. Today, it plays host to an increasing number of visitors who come for both business and pleasure. However, air pollution caused by nearby factories poses a major problem.



St. Nicholas's Church

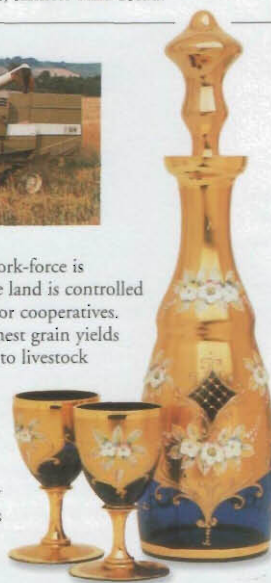


Farming

Only five per cent of the Czech work-force is employed in farming. Much of the land is controlled by large farms owned by the state or cooperatives. Czech farms have some of the highest grain yields in central Europe, but most is fed to livestock because the Republic specializes in meat and milk production.

Bohemian glass

Since the 1300s, the Bohemians of the south have made beautifully decorated glass from the fine sands found in this region. Bohemian glass is prized for its high quality, elegance, and delicacy.



CZECH REPUBLIC FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Prague
AREA	78,370 sq km (30,260 sq miles)
POPULATION	10,200,215
DENSITY	129 per sq km (335 per sq mile)
MAIN LANGUAGE	Czech
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Czech koruna
LIFE EXPECTANCY	76 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	333
GOVERNMENT	Multiparty democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%

Beer

Czech beers are popular all over the world, and Budweiser, Budvar, and Pilsner are household names. Brewing traditions go back hundreds of years.



Industry

The break-up of the communist regime led to the privatization of many Czech companies. However, some of the very large factories, such as the Skoda works at Plzen, remain under state control. Czech factories are able to produce about 200,000 cars a year. As well as cars, Skoda produces locomotives, machine tools, and weapons. The Czechs also produce iron and steel, machinery, and transport equipment, although there is a trend to move away from heavy industry into consumer goods such as textiles.